

Civil Rights and Development: A Global Cross-National Comparison

To what extent is there a correlation between the level of civil liberties and the level of development in a country?

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Introduction:

There is a social contract that exists between the government and the governed in any society. Jean-Jacques Rousseau famously stated, “Man is born free, and everywhere he is in chains” (The Editors of Encyclopaedia), implying that as soon as man is born, he immediately relinquishes his rights to society. Government exists to prevent men from murdering men. As humans, we live and abide by the social contract, an exchange of rights in which people give up natural rights in return for civil rights and liberties.

Civil liberties are the fundamental individual rights and freedoms protected by law, such as freedom of speech, religion, and assembly, and the right to privacy and due process. These freedoms are considered essential to a democratic society and are often enshrined in a country's constitution (The Editors of Encyclopaedia). This paper will examine whether or not civil liberties are essential for societies to be considered developed. This comparison will be accomplished by comparing the level of civil liberties, based on the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score, to three different development indices. Each of the three indices defines development slightly differently and gives more weight to specific factors when defining and quantifying development.

Development is the process of making economic, political, and social improvements for the well-being of all. The development process can occur in different ways; it can be led by a government and the striving for resources or by civil society and the pursuit of change. While development can lead to increased opportunities and improvements in standards of living, it can also widen gaps between the rich and poor and exacerbate existing inequalities (Glaeser, 2005). Inequality is the unequal or unjust distribution of resources and opportunities among members of society (The Editors of Encyclopaedia).

The remainder of this paper will cover an overview of the theory used and an explanation of the proposed hypothesis that the results would demonstrate the absence of a correlation between any of the three development indices and the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score. The paper will then discuss the chosen method of analyzing the coefficients of determination produced by all three analyses. Finally, this paper will conclude with the understanding that the proposed hypothesis was rejected because all of the analyses suggested at least a slight relationship between civil liberties and development, while one of the indices produced a stronger, moderate correlation.

Theory & Hypothesis:

This paper utilizes graphical analysis to determine if a correlation exists between the level of civil liberties present in a country and the level of development based on three development indices. In each of the three models, the independent variable will be the Freedom House ranking of civil liberties. The dependent variable will be a development index highlighting one development aspect, whether that be gender equality, economic growth, or environmental impact. A comparison is being drawn between two variables across all countries in which data is available, not two specific countries.

Like all studies, this one will have limitations. Most importantly, data are only available for a limited number of countries. The United Nations Development Program, the source of two indices, HDI and GDI, has data for an impressive 191 countries. The Happy Planet Index has only managed to collect data from 152 countries. All three indices are missing data from the Democratic People's Republic of Korea, Monaco, Nauru, and Somalia. For one reason or another, often connected to access to public data and freedom of information, all of the indices used in this paper will not include these countries. The Happy Planet Index excludes a further 39

countries due to non-honest reports on carbon emissions and human well-being, two critical factors in the index. Due to these exclusions, this paper will only be able to determine the relationship between the level of civil liberties and development for countries in which data is present; therefore, no matter what, there will be limitations within the findings, and countries will be missing. Whenever there is missing information, the country will be removed from that particular graph.

In full consideration of the limitations of the investigation and resources, my hypothesis before analyzing the data was that the results would demonstrate the absence of a correlation between any of the three development indices and the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score. The world we live in is not as simple as the one Rousseau theorized in his social contract. Today, the world is rife with countless political regimes that have all shown promise in one form of development or another; democratic just societies are not the only nations that have demonstrated the ability to succeed. The existence of these states is the reasoning behind the null hypothesis; the data behind these states will illustrate that a just democracy, one with high-ranking civil liberties, is not necessarily to be considered developed.

Methodology & Source Data:

The following section will explain the methodology employed in the paper and address all sources of data: Freedom House, United Nations Development Program, and Happy Planet Index.

Freedom House is a non-governmental organization based in Washington, D.C., most known for its political advocacy and research. The organization publishes an annual paper called *Freedom in the World*, in which 195 countries and 15 territories are ranked on their level of freedom. Freedom House quantifies the idea of freedom in two categories: political rights and

civil liberties. They award a score out of 40 to political rights and 60 to civil liberties; this combines to be a freedom score out of 100. These points are awarded based on a series of criteria that answer a series of questions, divided into political rights and civil liberties. There are ten criteria category questions for political rights and 15 for civil liberties. For each criteria category question, a country or territory can score between 1, meaning little to none, and 4, meaning absolute. This paper will focus on civil liberties, scored out of 60. The fifteen civil liberties criteria questions are divided into four sub-categories: freedom of expression and belief (4 questions), associational and organizational rights (3), the rule of law (4), and personal autonomy and individual rights (4). All of these subcategories are vital ideas in Rousseau's social contract. He and other philosophers believed these were the liberties people should gain while living in a society (Britannica, The Editors of Encyclopaedia).

Two of the three indices used in this paper come from the United Nations Development Program (UNDP). The UNDP is the development section of the world's largest intergovernmental organization, the United Nations. The Human Development Index (HDI) and the Gender Development Index (GDI) draw on data from various sources and programs run by the UNDP and the larger UN. HDI is considered the gold standard when looking at developmental indices, as it is the United Nations' way of judging if a country is developed. The UN chooses to quantify development by looking at three key categories: health is measured through life expectancy, education is measured through mean years of schooling and expected years of schooling, and income is measured through GNI per capita.¹ According to World-in-Data, HDI is calculated by multiplying the health, education,—the UN uses the

¹GNI, or Gross National Income, is a measure of economic development calculated by adding Gross Domestic Product and the difference between money flowing from foreign countries and money flowing to foreign countries. The version of this statistic used in HDI calculations is GNI per capita, meaning this value is then divided by the country's population.

arithmetic mean of the two education statistics—and income values. The product is then converted into the 1-0 index value through the following formula:

$$\text{Index value} = \frac{\text{actual value} - \text{minimum value}}{\text{maximum value} - \text{minimum value}}.$$

GDI is a lesser-known index also curated by the UNDP. This index uses gender-specific HDI values to compare women's and men's development, which is accomplished by creating a ratio of female to male HDI values.

The final source of data is the Happy Planet Index (HPI). Its website states, “It [is not an] indicat[or] [of] the most developed country in the traditional sense” (Happy Planet Index).

Instead, the creators believe that the index is a more nuanced approach to viewing development.

The HPI quantifies development with three statistics: one common and two very untraditional.

The traditional statistic is the life expectancy data from the UNDP. HPI, true to its name, then uses an environmental statistic, ecological footprint.² The final statistic used by HPI is the most untraditional “human well-being” data from the World Happiness Report.³ In the simplest form, to calculate HPI, the following formula must be followed:

$$\text{Index value} = \frac{\text{Life expectancy} \times \text{wellbeing}}{\text{Ecological footprint}}.^4$$

²“The average amount of land, measured using global hectares (gha) per person, needed to sustain a country’s typical consumption patterns, based on data prepared by the Global Footprint Network” (Happy Planet Index).

³HPI is referred to as “untraditional” because it relies largely on survey data. One of its core three statistics is based on the WHR. The WHR conducts yearly surveys worldwide to try to gauge people's happiness levels worldwide. However, an issue arises with sample size, and survey bias must be considered. The World Happiness Report website says, “A sample size of 2,000 to 3,000 is large enough to give a reasonably good estimate at the national level”. Here, the WHR themselves are stating that their data only results in a relatively good estimate (Helliwell, John F, 2021).

⁴In reality, a different, more complicated formula is used to ensure a balanced judgment of all three statistics (Happy Planet Index).

⁵This was accomplished by using the following formula $\text{Adjusted} = (\text{Initial Value} - \text{min value}) / (\text{max value} - \text{min value})$

known as the trend line. This line is an attempt to find a linear relationship between the two variables. Located above the graph is an R^2 value, also known as the coefficient of determination.⁶ The coefficient is intended to provide insight into the overall accuracy of the model and is calculated by the following formula: $R^2 = 1 - \frac{RSS}{TSS}$.⁷ In this scenario, it is attempting to show whether or not the linear trendline is actually accurate and if there is a linear correlation between the two variables. Generally, in social science, a coefficient of determination is considered strong if it is 0.7 or higher, deemed moderate if it is 0.3 to 0.7, and thought of as weak if it is less than 0.3 (Analytics Vidhya).

Figure One demonstrates the coefficient of determination for the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score, and HDI is 0.299, just below moderate. This means that the general hypothesis predicting no relationship between HDI and the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score is falsified by the empirical data. There is no significant relationship between the HDI quantification of development and the level of civil liberties, however, a slight, almost moderate correlation exists. The large number of countries that can be found in the top right corner of the graph does, however, begin to illustrate that high levels of HDI often correlate to high levels of civil liberties. For example, the United Kingdom and Canada, two countries that score above 0.900 in both categories, illustrate that oftentimes in developed countries citizens have strong liberties, such as the right to vote, freedom of speech and religion, and the right to demonstrate.

However, the countries in the bottom right corner show why there is not a clear linear relationship between the variables. Interestingly, many of these countries are oil-rich countries of the Middle East. Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and Qatar all call this corner of the

⁶“The coefficient of determination is a measurement used to explain how much the variability of one factor is caused by its relationship to another factor. This correlation is represented as a value between 0.0 and 1.0” (“Coefficient of Determination: How to Calculate It and Interpret the Result”).

⁷RSS = sum of squares of residuals & TSS = total sum of squares

graph home. These outliers to the linear trend are caused by the HDI measures of development. HDI measures health, schooling, and wealth. These three countries, as is common in oil-rich nations, score highly in two or three of these categories. Saudi Arabia has an extremely high average years of schooling at 16.11 and an extremely high life expectancy at 76.9. The United Arab Emirates has a high average of schooling at 15.7 and a very high gross national income per capita at \$62,574. Qatar has one of the largest life expectancies and gross national incomes per capita at 79.3 years and \$87,134, respectively (United Nations Development Program). All of these high statistics cause these oil-rich Middle Eastern countries to attain significant HDI scores, all above 0.855. However, the authoritative monarchies that exist in all of these countries withhold civil liberties from their public, causing extremely low scores on the Freedom House Civil Liberties Index. Oil-rich countries ruled by authoritarian monarchies stand out as a significant exception to the general notion that there is a correlation between a country's HDI and its level of civil liberties, as indicated by the Freedom House Index. These outliers explain why the coefficient of determination is low at 0.299.

The HDI is the United Nations' choice of defining and grasping development. Even if this analysis does not illustrate a substantial relationship between the level of civil liberties present in the country and its HDI score the investigation does successfully demonstrate that the United Nations does not believe civil liberties are a factor in development; illustrated by countries with breathtakingly low civil liberty scores who will arrest journalists for asking questions can still be considered developed by the United Nations.

Gender Development Index & Civil Liberties:

Rousseau's theory of the social contract was published in 1762 (The Editors of Encyclopaedia). The 1700s was a time of vastly worse gender disparity. GDI would never have

A scatter plot titled "Adjusted Gender Development Index Score" on the y-axis and "Adjusted Freedom House Civil Liberties Score" on the x-axis. The y-axis ranges from 0.450 to 1.000 with major ticks every 0.100. The x-axis ranges from 0.000 to 1.000 with major ticks every 0.200. A red regression line starts at approximately (0.05, 0.87) and ends at (1.0, 0.96). The legend indicates blue dots represent "Adjusted Score GDI". Numerous countries are labeled as points, such as Turkmenistan, Azerbaijan, Venezuela, Iran, Afghanistan, Yemen, Iraq, Chad, Pakistan, Nigeria, Togo, Niger, Liberia, India, Sierra Leone, Senegal, Benin, São Tomé and Príncipe, South Africa, Trinidad and Tobago, United Kingdom, Iceland, Switzerland, Sweden, and others. The density of labels increases towards the top right corner of the plot.

Examining Figure Two provides valuable insights into the patterns and relationships between civil liberties and gender equality. Though it appears that the data points are clustered around the trend line, and one may assume this would indicate a strong relationship between the variables, this is not supported by the data. By delving deeper into the details presented in Figure

Two, specifically by examining the coefficient of determination, the R^2 value, the relationship between these variables falls below even a moderate level of correlation.

It is interesting to note that every single data point on the graph falls within the top half. This trend is the result of generally high GDI values. All but a few outliers fall within the top fifth, over 0.800 GDI, of the graph. However, it is important to contextualize these values. The UNDP places all countries into categories based on their GDI values; countries with scores above 0.900 are placed in one of the top four groups, whereas countries that score below 0.900 are in the fifth and last group. GDI is a comparison between the HDI for men and women in a given country. Therefore, a score of less than 0.900, in truth, illustrates a large disparity in gender equality; for countries with dramatically lower scores, like Afghanistan, Chad, and Yemen, a mammoth disparity exists.

Though Figure Two illustrates that there is little to no correlation between civil liberties and GDI, it is fascinating to note that all countries with a GDI score lower than 0.800, which means a massive disparity in HDI for women and men, have an adjusted civil liberties score of less than 0.400. Though there may not be a correlation between the level of gender development and the level of civil liberties, there is a trend that poor gender development is linked to a lack of civil liberties.

Afghanistan is a perfect example of the aforementioned trend. Since the Taliban's re-seizing of the country, freedom of speech has disappeared (Amnesty International). The Taliban's enforcement of strict Islamic Law has also caused the rights of women to disappear. Journalists are being prosecuted for reporting on the government, and girls are being forced out of school (Amnesty International). A decrease in civil liberties is being seen at the same time as a decrease in gender development. In Yemen, massive education disparities exist between genders,

and the Houthis and the Yemeni government impose unnecessary restrictions and regulations on humanitarian organizations and aid projects, causing major human rights violations (Human Rights Watch). Once again, there is a connection between a large gender disparity and poor civil liberties.

The results of the second analysis failed to illustrate a strong trend between the two variables, but it did illustrate that poor performance on GDI is often tied to poor levels of civil liberties. There is little correlation between the two variables over the entire scale, but when just examining the worst-performing countries, a correlation is apparent. It is essential to understand that correlation does not necessarily equal causation. Countries like Turkmenistan, which has an adjusted GDI score of 0.925, placing it in the penultimate group, and an abysmal adjusted civil liberties score of 0.033, illustrate that low GDI can be an indicator of low civil liberties and not vice versa. A country can be poorly performing and withhold civil rights and liberties from its citizens without also having a massive gender disparity in HDI.

Happy Planet Index & Civil Liberties:

The final analysis, the Happy Planet Index, used a less typical definition and quantification of development. HPI takes an untraditional approach by considering happiness and ecological footprint in its quantification of development. This investigation will provide an interesting alternative angle to the two previous tests. This specific analysis will also examine if a correlation between happiness and civil liberties and ecological footprint and civil liberties exists. Once again, both values were normalized to a score between 0 and 1, and the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score was used as the independent variable. The result: Figure 3, the most chaotic graph thus far.

Figure 3: Freedom House Civil Liberties Score vs. Happy Planet Index

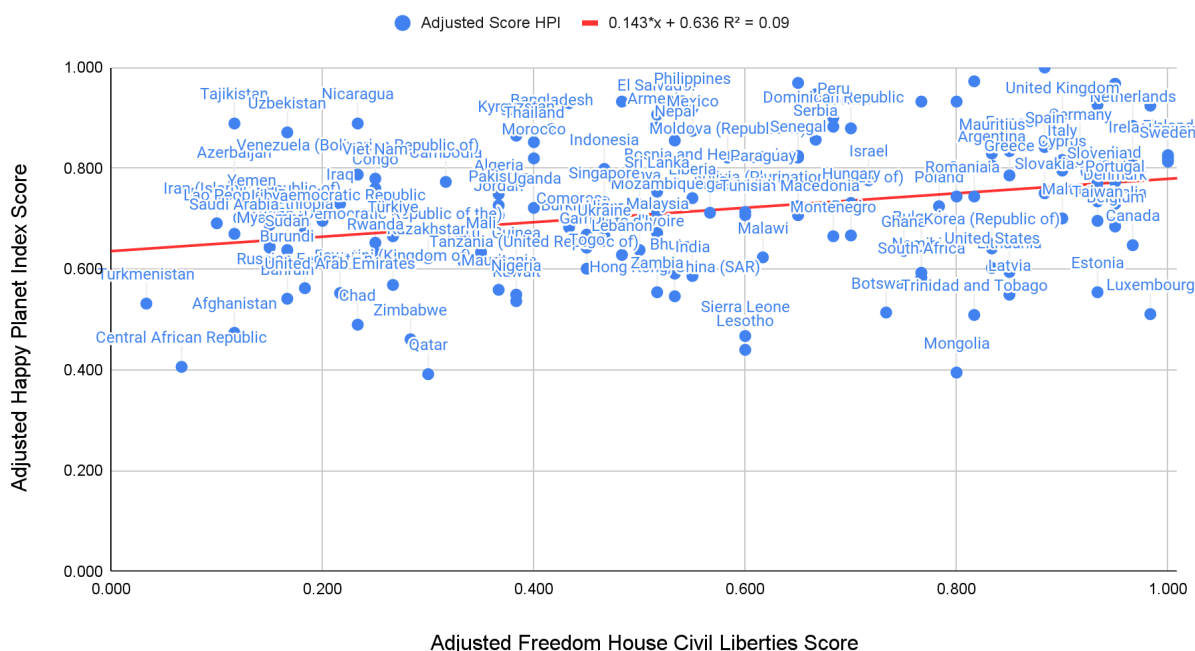


Figure 3 reveals the lowest coefficient of determination of any of the studies at 0.09, far below the threshold for even a moderate effect. Unlike the previous two case studies, which both demonstrated a slight correlation, the 0.09 coefficient of determination suggests a very minimal connection between the HPI score and the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score. Even though the R^2 value is so low, indicating no correlation, there is still a lot to be learned and understood from this graph. Figure 3 is the first of the three analyses to reveal countries that are considered developed by traditional measures behind or below the trendline due to their HPI scores.

HPI's nontraditional approach to measuring development is the reason why so many countries traditionally considered developed and countries that score so high on the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score fall below the trend line in Figure 3. Luxembourg is an outstanding case study in this regard. The small country has an incredibly high Freedom House Civil Liberties Score of 0.983 and incredibly High HDI and GDI values of 0.930 and 0.960, which

caused it to be in the top right-hand corner of the previous two graphs, but its low HPI score of 0.510 causes it to fall in the bottom half of the graph. When using HPI to analyze development, Luxembourg would not be considered a prime example of a thriving country; instead, it would be seen as an example of a country that provides freedom to its people but lacks an acknowledgment of the planet.

Figure 3 illustrates the striking fact that environmental impact is not considered in traditional definitions of development. Countries like Luxembourg have been routinely in the upper echelon of Figure 1 and Figure 2 in the previous two case studies, but drop to the bottom 2/3 of Figure 3. Figure 3 not only illustrates that there's practically no correlation between civil liberties and the HPI, but also suggests that there's very little correlation between civil liberties and sustainable environmental practices. Countries that traditionally score higher on the HPI scale have lower ecological footprints, as it is one of the critical factors in the index. It can, therefore, be assumed, based on the findings of Figure 3 and the knowledge of the component making up the HPI, that there is not a strong correlation between the level of civil liberties and forward-thinking positive environmental standing and practices.

Interestingly, the bottom left of the graph has also drastically changed. Countries like the United Arab Emirates and Qatar that scored well in GDI, 0.953 and 0.985, and HDI, 0.911 and 0.855, scored poorly in HPI. Some of these countries are also the newly oil-rich nations discussed in the first case study of this paper. Those countries are beginning to increase their HDI scores through impressive economic development, but these results suggest they may be doing so at the cost of the planet. The oil industry that is booming in these countries is likely causing the ecological footprint of the countries to skyrocket further, causing their HPI score to drop.

Conclusion:

This paper aimed to determine if there was a connection or correlation between civil liberties and development. This paper attempted to take a description of words and turn it into numbers that could be used as a variable in an experiment. The problem is that development is a complicated concept and idea, not simply one quantifiable statistic. Three different quantifications of development were used to overcome this problem; they each highlight different aspects of development ideas. First, the Human Development Index, the traditional quantification used by the United Nations, was chosen to stress the importance of economic prosperity and education. Second, the Gender Development Index highlights the disparity of HDI between men and women, emphasizing the importance of gender equality in development. Finally, the Happy Planet Index was selected to highlight the importance of citizens' happiness and ecological footprint in development.

The hypothesis that the analysis results would demonstrate no correlation between development and civil liberties was not supported by the data. The first experiment's results, HDI, indicated a weak correlation due to its coefficient of determination being 0.299. The determination coefficient of 0.299 would be rounded up to 0.3. In computational social science, a determination coefficient of 0.3 to 0.7 suggests a slight correlation (Analytics Vidhya). Though the results of the second and third analyses align more closely with the hypothesis predicting no relationship between the two variables, they, too, reveal a positive relationship between development and civil liberties, albeit of a smaller magnitude. It is crucial to remember that correlation does not necessarily equal causation and that this paper does not prove that civil liberties cause development or vice versa.

In summary, this paper found a small correlation between the level of development and civil liberties in a country. Interestingly, the measurement of development that most clearly disproves this hypothesis and demonstrates a correlation was HDI, the same measurement used by the United Nations. The United Nations is an institution with the goal of fostering global cooperation and conversation; it is the largest international government or organization on the planet, founded on the principles of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Articles 18, 19, and 20 of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights provide people with freedom of religion, freedom of speech, and the freedom to demonstrate peacefully (United Nations). All the aforementioned rights are civil liberties measured in the Freedom House Civil Liberties Score. The only developmental index that showed any correlation to civil liberties is used by the United Nations, which also recognizes all of the forenamed civil liberties as human rights.

There's a social contract that exists between the government and the governed. Today, that social contract is more complicated than ever before. In the media, there are debates over what freedoms and liberties citizens should have. People take to the streets and protest against their government's inability to govern. The chaos of the modern world makes it so that civil liberties are more important than ever before. Development is a convoluted concept that attempts to track the progress of countries. There is no one definition or quantifiable means of measuring development. This paper examined whether or not countries that grant their citizens more liberties would be considered more developed. The results demonstrated that it depended on the definition of development. Therefore, the question left to be answered is what truly makes a country developed and what rights the governed should relinquish to the government in the social contract.

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